2.1 A Country in Crisis

In 1820 and again in 1850, compromises had held the United States together. But how many times can you compromise before someone finally cries, "enough already"?

MAIN IDEA The Kansas-Nebraska Act deepened the conflict over slavery and led to the eruption of violence in these territories.

THE KANSAS-NEBRASKA ACT

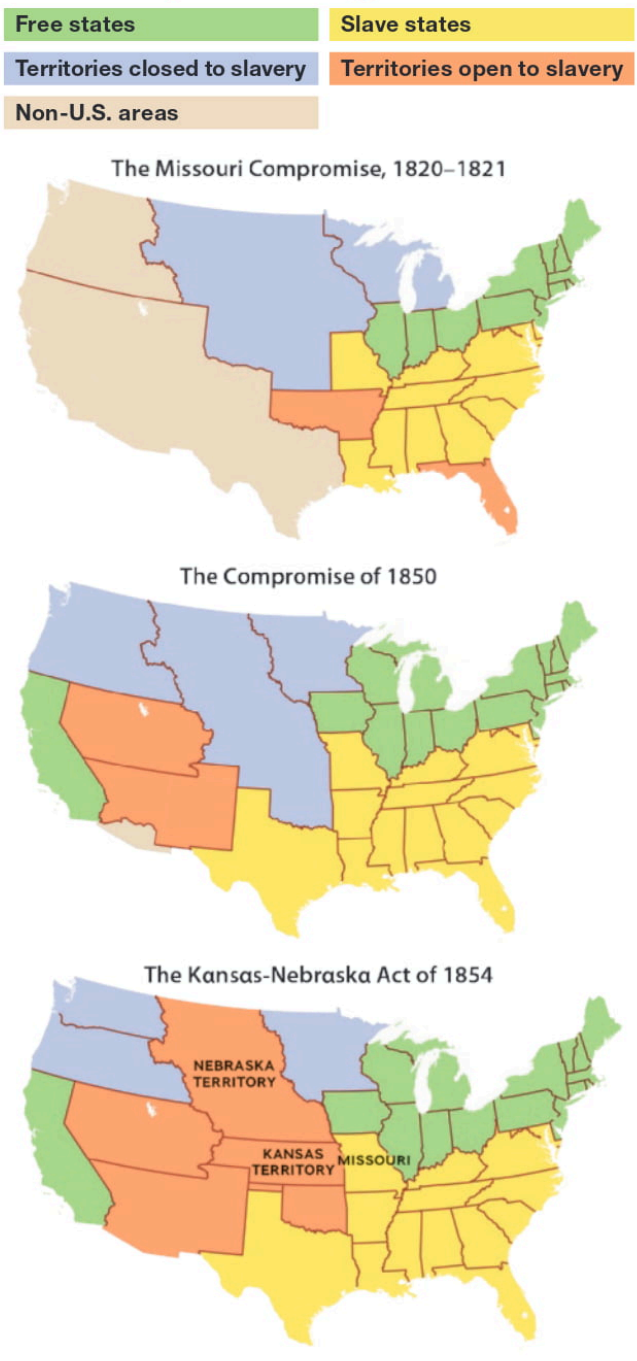
The discovery of gold in California in 1848 had increased interest in building a railroad to the Pacific coast. **Stephen A. Douglas**, a senator from Illinois, lobbied for the railroad to run through his state. Douglas, who was a great supporter of national expansion, proposed a route stretching from the Illinois city of Chicago west to San Francisco, California.

However, there were problems with this route. Before a railroad could cross the territory west of Minnesota, Iowa, and Missouri, the territory would have to be organized into new states. But the Missouri Compromise had banned slavery in this area. The prospect of new free states infuriated, or enraged, southerners and once again threatened the country's unity.

Douglas introduced a bill that dealt with these issues. It called for the territory to be split into two smaller territories called Kansas and Nebraska, which could then become states. It also called for the repeal of the Missouri Compromise, which would end the long-standing ban on slavery in the North.

The bill, however, did not dictate whether slavery would actually be permitted in the new states. It left that decision to the people. This approach is called **popular sovereignty** (SAHV-run-tee) and allows residents to decide an issue by voting. Douglas had developed this idea, but many northerners, especially in New England, disagreed with it. Despite the strong opposition to popular sovereignty, Douglas managed to push the bill through Congress. It was signed into law in May 1854 as the **Kansas-Nebraska Act**.

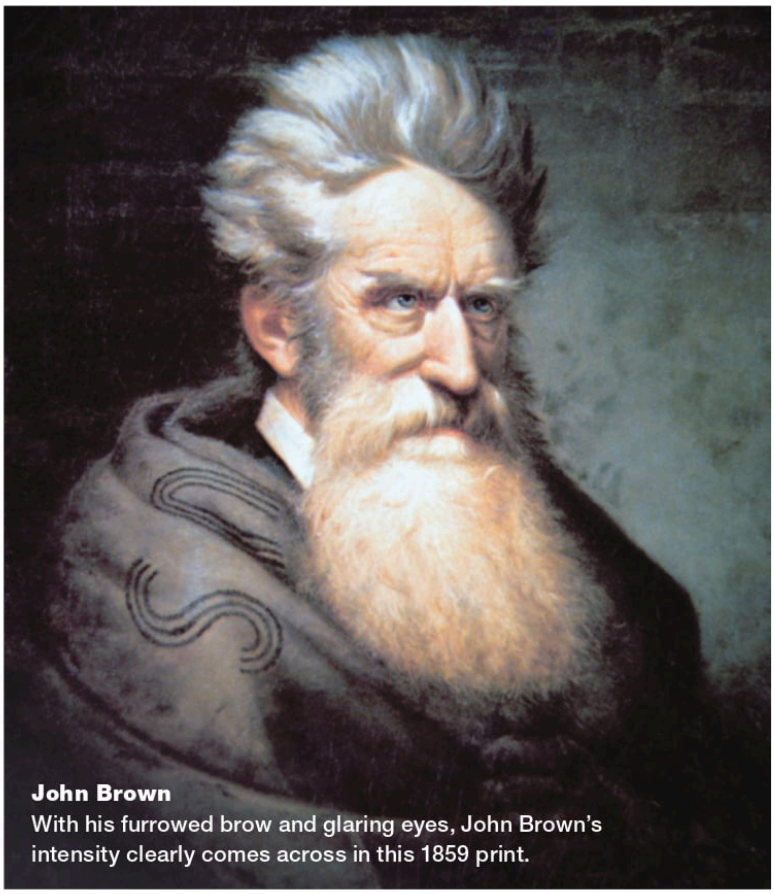
Three Compromise Acts, 1820–1854



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"BLEEDING KANSAS"

Douglas predicted that the Kansas-Nebraska Act would "impart peace to the country [and] stability to the Union." Instead, Kansas became a battleground in the slavery conflict. Antislavery "Free-Soilers," or members of the Free-Soil Party in the North, organized like-minded groups of people to settle in the new territory and vote against slavery there. Free-Soilers hoped that by populating Kansas with people who felt as they did, they could ensure that the territory would become a free state.



John Brown
With his furrowed brow and glaring eyes, John Brown's intensity clearly comes across in this 1859 print.

But southerners were just as determined to make Kansas a slave state. When elections were held, thousands of slavery supporters from Missouri crossed the border to vote illegally. These "border ruffians," as they were called, were actually not needed because many southerners and slavery supporters already lived in Kansas. Proslavery forces gained control of the legislature in 1855 and passed a series of harsh laws against those who opposed slavery. Antislavery settlers then created their own government within the state and worked through the summer and fall of 1855 to write their own constitution. Over the winter, the Free-Soilers elected a legislature and governor. Groups sympathetic to their cause in the Northeast sent them rifles, while southerners sent a 300-man expedition to support the proslavery settlers.

The situation soon turned violent. In May 1856, a large group of slavery supporters raided the town of Lawrence, Kansas, a free-soil stronghold. They burned down a hotel, destroyed a newspaper office, and threw printing presses into the river. In revenge, a militant, or extremist, abolitionist named **John Brown** led four of his sons and several other men to a proslavery settlement at Pottawatomie (pot-uh-WAH-tuh-mee) Creek. There, they pulled five men out of their houses and brutally murdered them. Federal troops pursued Brown, but he managed to escape. Brown fled north where he was protected by other abolitionists. Because of the violence in Lawrence, Pottawatomie Creek, and other places, Americans began calling the territory "Bleeding Kansas." Eventually, order was restored in Kansas, but the political struggle over slavery continued.

The violence even reached Washington, D.C. Preston Brooks, a representative from South Carolina, had been angered by an antislavery speech given by Massachusetts senator Charles Sumner. When Brooks entered the Senate chamber, he severely beat Sumner with a cane. Soon, the split in the country over slavery would involve the Supreme Court.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What approach did the Kansas-Nebraska Act take toward the issue of slavery in the Kansas and Nebraska territories?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What violent incident occurred as a result of a senator's speech opposing slavery?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** How did U.S. territories represented in the Compromise of 1850 map change after the Kansas-Nebraska Act was passed?

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